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Bob Hardaway

Bob Hardaway was born in Milwaukee on March 1, 1928. He played clarinet and tenor sax during his military service and joined Ray Anthony's group in the early 50s. Bob has played with a long list of top band leaders including Woody Herman, Benny Goodman, Stan Kenton and Bud Shank. He has recorded with Bob Florence and still performs in the Los Angeles area.

Bob was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 14, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Los Angeles. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm pleased to have veteran musician Bob Hardaway with me.

BH: Thank you.

MR: You know it's a long way from Milwaukee. That's where you came from?

BH: I was born in Milwaukee, yes.

MR: Did your family stay there?

BH: We left when I was three years old, I couldn't find a rhythm section.

MR: Good one, good one. I like that.

BH: And so we came out here and have been up in this general area.

MR: So you're really almost a native Californian.

BH: Yes, indeed.

MR: What did your parents do when they came out here?

BH: Well my father was a cartoonist and he was working on the *Kansas City Star* for a while and then he went to a newspaper in Milwaukee that I don't recall the name of. But he was actually a political cartoonist, and I have some of those drawings which are wonderful to have.

MR: Do you, that's great.

BH: And then he came out here and he got into the cartoon business, because a friend of his offered him a job out here who had an independent cartoon company. And this person's name was Ub Iwerks. And he became very well known and famous, as a matter of fact he won an Academy Award for special effects on the movie "The Birds." Do you remember that movie by Hitchcock?

MR: Certainly. Hitchcock, yeah.

BH: Well he's the one that figured out how it would look like there was all those birds when there really weren't all those birds.

MR: Oh, neat.

BH: And he also is the one that put together the Mr. Lincoln display I guess you'd call it, at Disneyland, where they have a thing, it's a dummy that looks like Lincoln, and it does the Gettysburg Address with motions and all. He figured that one out way, way back. At any rate he eventually became the head of the special effects department at Disney, and he passed away quite some time ago. Anyway he gave my father his first job and from there my father went into Warner Brothers, where he originated one of the country's most famous cartoon characters, which was Bugs Bunny.

MR: No kidding.

BH: Yup. His name was Bugs Hardaway, that was his name, but he was named after him. And so he did that at Loony Tunes, Merry Melody Cartoons at Warner Brothers.

MR: How old were you when Bugs Bunny was invented?

BH: Let's see, how old would I have been? I think he had his 60th birthday, and I'm 70. So I must have been about ten I guess, or thereabouts.

MR: Do you have any memory of your father talking about this thing I'm working on at work and—

BH: Well what happened was they had a cast of cartoon characters, one of them was a rabbit, I believe it was called Oswald. And it was a conventional rabbit. I mean its ears hung down and it went on all fours. And they wanted to update this character somehow, so the cartoonists all submitted their suggestions and ideas. And it turned out that my father's was the one that was selected. And so Mel Blanc, the famous voice person, they were going to call it the Happy Rabbit originally. And Mel said, and he has quoted this in his book also, that he said well why don't you name him after the guy that drew him and call him Bugs, after Bugs Hardaway. So that's the true story.

MR: That's cool.

BH: Yeah, that's pretty neat. Now they have all these — you know what cells are?

MR: Yes.

BH: The animation cells? Well those were so plentiful and common when I was a kid that I didn't think a thing about it. And I don't have any. And they were around all the time. And they are very valuable now, and very expensive. And I don't have any of those.

MR: That's too bad.

BH: Yeah. But you wouldn't know.

MR: Yeah it's funny when you think about what your parents do, that sometimes it doesn't have significance until—

BH: You take it for granted, you know, because I was always exposed to it. Through that I actually met the musical director — he went from there to Walter Lantz, and he was very influential in bringing about Woody Woodpecker as well. And if you think about it

they're pretty much the same characters, they're both smart alecks. And so I had met the musical director of the cartoons at Walter Lantz, his name was Darrel Calker. And he became a mentor to me and gave me some education and help. I was interested in writing for a while and he was helping me with that. So that was all good. It was all good stuff.

MR: How did the saxophone become your instrument of choice?

BH: Well I started on a little piano, and then I started on the clarinet when I was ten years old, and I played that for about five years. And then I heard Coleman Hawkins play "Body and Soul," and I thought that's for me, so I got a tenor saxophone. And I started rather late for a lot of people, I was 15. You know people start early in that these days. But that's the way I got into the saxophone.

MR: So 15, and you were born in 1928, right? So the music around the house and off the radio mostly consisted of what?

BH: Well you didn't really have much jazz. You had some remotes, because some of the bands were still happening then. And you'd have remotes from some different ballrooms and things throughout the country, some of them I could get, and I would hear some of that. And then of course I would go to see them when they came to Los Angeles. They'd have four or five different places they were playing in. I got in, when I got into, the first time I went on the road was one year after I started the saxophone. Well I knew how to read music already from the clarinet so that was half the battle there. And I was 16 then, that first time I went on the road. And it was a beginning that started 20 years of traveling, about, off and on. I wasn't on the road all the time because I was back going to school and different things, but off and on I did the road for about 20 years.

MR: How did your parents feel about this — what seemed to start a career for you?

BH: They were supportive. They were concerned the first time I went on the road at 16, and my father gave me a talk about girls. And the war was still on then, because this was in 1944. And things were in short supply, certain things. And one of them were white dress shirts. And I needed them for this, which I didn't have because I never had jobs before. So my mother went all over and ended up finding me six white shirts, but one here, one there, whatever. And they were quite concerned when they packed me up and sent me away.

MR: Yeah. Who was that with?

BH: It was a local band named Chuck Cabot, and he was a — also he was coach of high school. And his brother was Johnny Richards.

MR: The writer?

BH: Yes.

MR: Yeah, okay.

BH: The family name was Cascales actually. And that was the first time I was ever exposed to any sort of racial prejudice as well was at that time.

MR: How so?

BH: Well we only had one black person on the band, he was the jazz tenor player. And I was the subordinate player.

MR: Second tenor.

BH: Second tenor. And we got to Spokane, Washington where we were going to play at the Natitorium Park Ballroom, and they didn't allow any black people in the park. And he had family up there. It was quite an eye opener for me. I just hadn't been exposed to it before. But also in a way the bandleader was very cheap, so he didn't get another player, we played with four saxophones and I became the jazz tenor player.

MR: In other words, they didn't even let the musician come in either?

BH: No, oh no, no. He couldn't even come in the park.

MR: What an awful scene that must have been.

BH: It was terrible, mostly, it was terrible for him and for me.

MR: And his family.

BH: Yes indeed. He had some of us over to his family's house and all. So anyway but then I was put into the hot seat, and had to get my feet wet right away.

MR: We'll just pause for our coffee here for a moment.

MR: Yeah I thought sometimes the black musicians could play, but the black audience—

BH: But that's true, sometimes that was the case. He was a local player too, I think his name was Walter Benton. And I heard about him for a few years but then I didn't. I don't know what became of him.

MR: So you got thrown into the solo tenor chair.

BH: That's indeed the case.

MR: Had you done much improvising before that?

BH: A little bit. I liked Benny Goodman when I was playing the clarinet and my neighbor across the street played the drums. And we'd get together and do Benny Goodman and Gene Krupa, just the two of us. So I had a little bit, but I didn't have, at that point I had just started studying harmony. In high school I started studying harmony. And that turned into a many year study that I spent a lot of time studying in different — starting from scratch twice, three times actually, and so I got a pretty thorough foundation in harmony, which helped a whole lot, because I had an average, or a little bit better than average ear. I didn't have a great ear. And so I had to use my head as much as my ears to play.

MR: Yeah. So if you saw E minor seven in your chart, you kind of knew what to do with that.

BH: Exactly. I knew exactly what to do with it.

MR: You knew exactly what to do with it.

BH: Oh yes. I knew a lot about harmony and relationships, one chord to the other. But if I was to have to depend on my ear entirely I wouldn't do nearly as well without the paper you know. Although I have done a lot of that too but usually it's material that I know well.

MR: Well that's advice that's good for students sometimes, if you have some of each, your rate of success could be higher.

BH: Yeah. Things were really different when I started too, Monk. If you had one saxophone player in a band in those days that could improvise, that's about all you had. Or in any section. But nowadays, with the education system, it has been so improved, particularly with professionals teaching it and not just educators teaching it but really professionals that know what they're talking about, clinics and that sort of thing, everybody now can play. In fact it's unusual if somebody can't play a good jazz solo.

MR: Over the years did the solo player get a little more salary?

BH: No not in my case. That never happened with me. I was always happy to have the job and didn't really try to get extra money.

MR: You didn't try to push it. You went from, was this around '43 you said—

BH: '44 is when I first went on the road.

MR: Okay. A lot of musicians were in the service.

BH: True.

MR: Did that have an effect on — I mean is that why you got this job do you think?

BH: Well this was pretty much a young band. This was mostly kids you know.

MR: No kidding.

BH: About my age, yeah. I think the oldest guy in the band was a guy named Johnny Polonski and I think he was 19, and I think he was the oldest guy in the band. I mean he got kids you know, because we didn't make very much money. And John Polonski ended up having a terrific career, his name became John Parker, and he did a lot of film work. He did music for a lot of television series and motion pictures. He did very well. But that was the beginning of it and that sort of got me hooked. A sort of humorous story, I was very naive and all at that time in most every way. And the first night when we opened, five of us were sharing this two room hotel, because of the money. And they got a couple of girls to come up to the room. You know, these guys? Gee whiz. And so I went out, left the next day and went to the Y. True story.

MR: Yeah. You remembered what your father said. Something's going to happen, and he was right.

BH: That's sort of fun though.

MR: So 1946, did you decide to enlist?

BH: I did enlist, yes indeed I did. And what happened was I went to the Air Force, I was going to enlist in the Air Force. And the day we were being inducted there was a band, from San Diego, a young band. At this time *Look* Magazine had a band contest, nationwide. And this band placed third in the nationwide, from San Diego. And so they were inducted as a unit, they enlisted as a unit, and they were told that they would stay together and be stationed at Westover Field, Massachusetts, and play for recruiting purposes and entertainment, USO type things. The baritone player and the tenor player from that band didn't pass the physical. And it happened to be that my friend, who was a baritone player, and is actually the reason I was enlisting because I was going to be drafted anyway so I thought we'd stay together. So we enlisted together and we joined that band, it was just a coincidence that it had worked out that way. Well they were not used for recruiting purposes, and my friend ended up in Newfoundland, and I went with the good part of this band to Panama.

MR: That's a long way from Massachusetts.

BH: A long ways from Massachusetts. But that turned out to be a very good experience too because in Panama I started studying privately from a musician down there, studying harmony and counterpoint, and I wrote a library for that band as a young person, as I was, and we did a show that toured the Caribbean area: Haiti and Jamaica, Puerto Rico and a bunch of different places down there, for which I was the conductor of this band, and had written most of the music. So I thought that was going to be a start of something for me. And then when I got out of the service I went to a junior college in Los Angeles. Actually I wanted to go to Eastman and I made application and there was a two year wait at that time, so I didn't want to wait so I got started. And I started studying harmony yet a third time from the very beginning, so it was easy for me.

MR: Yeah. Straight A's, right?

BH: Indeed. But I wouldn't have missed it for the world, having it taught to me like that. So I did that for a couple of years and then went to a private school called the American Operatic Laboratory, which I was studying composition there with a particular guy. I went there because this — he was approved by the Veterans. And there was a well known composer teaching there so I studied a bit with him. But actually I had to make a choice before I went there, because I didn't feel I had enough talent to be a Gerry Mulligan, who could write and play, or an Al Cohn, who could write and play the way I like to write and play, or a handful of others, Bill Holman. And so I chose the playing. I decided I'd let the writing — forget it, and be a player. So that's when I started really trying to apply myself to that.

MR: It's interesting because other fellows have had similar decisions, like you mentioned Bill Holman, and he went the other way.

BH: Yeah. Well he had quite a good career of playing though too.

MR: I wanted to just backtrack for a moment, in the service, you said that when you were with this band in '43 you saw your first instance of segregation and so forth. What was the service like in that regard?

BH: The same. We took Basic Training in Texas, and we mentioned something about that earlier, but there are some problems there, and the people were segregated pretty well. I think they had black units and all. There was a black piano player that — we didn't have a piano player actually, I forget how that worked out — no I know what it was, the piano player that was with this group really wasn't a jazz player. And we wanted to play sometimes. So there was this black piano player but we'd play with him. But he was in a different area from us, entirely. You know I didn't see anything blatant at that time.

MR: Pretty well in place.

BH: Yeah, I think so.

MR: So you got into big bands when the big band era had had its real popular run.

BH: At the very end.

MR: But it was still going on enough that you could find work.

BH: Yeah, there were still some ballrooms, and this was before the era of every band was a ghost band. Every band has a ghost leader now and maybe more than one.

MR: Yeah, that's right.

BH: How many Benny Goodman's Tributes have there been? They can't say the Benny Goodman Band, but they have to say a "Tribute" to, I'm sure Abe told you that. He just did one in Japan recently. But there were still some bands. The first so-called name band, I played with a few bands, panic sort of bands. The first name band I played with was Ray Anthony. And I think it was '51, I think. I lost track a little bit, but it was either '51 or '52. That's close enough. And he was very hot at the time. He was about the last one that made it. One of the other bands that made it for a while, it didn't last as long as Ray, was Sy Zentner got a band and I was on that band as well. But the rest of the bands were just rehashing the Glenn Miller and Tommy Dorsey and things.

MR: How did the "Bunny Hop" come around?

BH: Oh I don't know. Ray, it's supposedly his tune you know. It seems like Ray would jump on whatever bandwagon was hot. And if a hit record came out he'd try to make something similar, only actually patterning it exactly almost after what was the hit. I saw him do that many times. And I'm not sure how — they were doing it when we were on the band. And also one of his other shticks he used to do was the band used to walk single

file through the audience and around the rooms in the ballrooms, playing "The Saints." And the first night I joined the band we left from here going to Las Vegas — excuse me we went from Las Vegas going to Salt Lake. And there was an accident, the band had an accident, the driver drove into a culvert and threw — nobody was seriously injured, but threw everybody out of their seat, broken noses and—

MR: Your first night?

BH: My first night.

MR: Oh great.

BH: And I was unknown, I didn't know anybody, and this band was pretty well organized, they'd been together for a while, and so I was in the very back of the bus, they had a rack with the clothes that could hang across the back. And I was the seat right in front of it, and all the clothes came on me. And one of the guys, a guy who broke his nose, he's bleeding over his wife, and the singer, who was so upset that he soiled his pants. And so, and there was a picture in the next month's *Down Beat* when from there we went up north to Oregon, Portland. And there was a picture up there, and here's the band on the bandstand and it had all these people bandaged. You know, a guy with a patch over his nose, and one guy's shoulder bandaged up and things. And so some of the guys didn't have to walk then for "The Saints"—But that was sort of fun.

MR: Oh I see. They gave them a dispensation

BH: Got them off the hook temporarily. I spent quite a number of years though, off and on, 40 years off and on working for Ray. He didn't travel all the time and he had a small group for a while and I did that and did some touring, South America and things. And I've had quite a long relationship with that that started, I guess it was back in '51.

MR: Yeah. Was the "Bunny Hop" something that came out from someone else and he covered it? Or was it his thing?

BH: No, the "Bunny Hop" was his.

MR: It was his thing.

BH: He's credited as being the composer. And he made a lot of money because they sold a lot of records of that. But that dance was a certain thing that was a line dance. [scats] People would hop three times. People seem to, well it was game like, it was sort of fun I guess.

MR: Yeah. It seems like every few years another one comes along, where you had people doing that to "Alley Cat" and then the "Macarena" and some things never change I guess.

BH: No I guess not. But we traveled. I was never on that band for like year in, year out traveling. First I started subbing for a wonderful tenor player who passed away named Buddy Weiss. He was a wonderful tenor player. But he had his problems with drug abuse. And he would get in trouble every so often and he'd have to leave the band and

then I'd fill in for him. And then eventually he was not there anymore so I had the job. But then Ray wasn't traveling all the time either. He was staying around and would just go out occasionally.

MR: So were you establishing a career off the road in the L.A. area?

BH: Yeah, I played the clarinet and the saxophone, and by the time I was 30 I felt, having heard a lot of players, that I could play at a par with them, but I wasn't getting any of the good work in town, the studio work. And I was trying to figure out why. So I decided maybe I'd do better if I became a multi-doubler. So I was 30 at the time and I took up both the flute and the oboe at the same time, and really applied myself to them. And two years later I got a job on the staff orchestra at NBC, they still had a staff orchestra then, that was in the early 60s, as the oboe doubler. And I ended up having it all. I had all the flutes, the piccolo, the alto flute, the C flute, the bass flute.

MR: Oh, you even had a bass flute.

BH: The bass flute. I still have it but I've used it four times or something. That was because of, well let's see who was it, Mancini was the one that made — Hank Mancini was the one that made the alto flute popular, and so everybody had to have an alto flute then. And then he may also have been the one that used the bass flute maybe. I don't remember. But anyway I also had the English horn and the oboe, and the clarinet and the bass clarinet, and all the saxophones.

MR: And a small moving van.

BH: Well the difficult part about choosing that direction was it was rare when you'd know — I started doing calls then after that. After I got my staff job, then I started doing a lot of other calls as well. And it was rare when you got a call that you knew what you were going to be expected of you.

MR: No kidding? They wouldn't tell you, bring your English horn and your alto flute?

BH: No. Rarely. The contractors, to protect themselves, would say you better bring everything. So here I'd pack all this stuff in the trunk of my car, and you can imagine, like 13, maybe 13 instruments, to try to keep them at a recording level of proficiency, with reed instruments, and particularly, that was hard work. I'd have to touch them all, almost daily. Maybe not really practice them but at least put some air through them, and make sure that they're playing right, that they work.

MR. Yeah. You don't want to be on the call and then all of a sudden like uh oh, this horn is not playing.

BH: Well you wouldn't be back the next time. They are very unforgiving.

MR: Wow. It must have been, just from a logistical standpoint too, I picture like leaving all those instruments in your car all day if you didn't use them.

BH: Yeah, it was a problem. I had what they call a space blanket, it was like a thin, it looked sort of like aluminum foil with another kind of backing that would help to keep them from overheating. I put this over all these guys you know. So that was hard work, but it paid well, because doubling paid well, in particular in recording work and motion picture work and film/television work. The doubling didn't pay as well in live television. I did a lot of live television work. I did a lot during the 60s and 70s, there must have been eight or ten musical variety shows on the air. There was Dean Martin and Carol Burnett, Sonny & Cher, Jack Benny, Red Skelton — oh gosh, Danny Thomas had a show. This was before his comedy show, he had a variety show. And somehow I ended up on most of them. That became my most busy field actually.

MR: How did that work from a set up standpoint? Where was the band as opposed to the actors and actresses?

BH: In live television?

MR: Yes.

BH: Usually they were like on the side. Carol Burnett, there was the audience, here is the audience here and here's the stage here, and the band was right here, abutting onto the stage but on the side of the audience behind a glass. You could see the audience but it had glass up there to keep the sound, some of the sound out. And on the Dean Martin Show, which was a very popular show, it was similarly set up but you couldn't see the audience because it was like drapes in between you and the audience. They were all similar to that. Occasionally, I did a lot of the Dick Clark production shows as well. Some of those the band was on stage, actually on stage. Then there was the Laugh-In Show which was another terrific show.

MR: Did you guys ever have trouble keeping a straight face on those kind of things?

BH: Oh yeah. Laugh-In was great.

MR: I have this really specific memory, I don't know if you were on playing the Dean Martin Show. You know he would always come out and jump on the piano, and one time they had a collapsible piano?

BH: Yeah.

MR: Were you on the show then?

BH: Yeah, sure.

MR: That was so funny.

BH: I think the show was on ten years, and I was on there seven. And when the staff orchestra ended then I left because I got a chance to do the Carol Burnett Show, which was a better paying show. And as a matter of fact I had a tenor solo on the theme of the Dean Martin show that was very prominent, and was heard throughout the country. And Les Brown

was the bandleader on the show. And then he'd go on the road and they'd ask the tenor player if he was the one that played on the — and he wasn't. He wasn't even on the show, you know, if he played that solo. So it got a lot of exposure.

MR: Great.

BH: Yeah, it was good, it was nice.

MR: Do you get residuals for some of that work? Is that the right term?

BH: Um hum. Yes. There are residuals on live television. We have like six different contracts in the music business. We have film and T.V. film, I guess they're pretty much the same, live television, we have commercials and we have records and there's one other. At any rate, each one is a different contract, it has to be negotiated each time. Now they've never got residuals on film work. In fact we went on strike one time to try to get them. So in other words all these television series, dramatic series that you see, years later that are re-shown, you know on cable and so forth, they'll show the whole series over again, maybe it's — some of them are great shows you know. But the musicians don't get paid for that.

MR: Like "Gunsmoke" for instance?

BH: That's right. That's the idea. But you get paid like in live television what you call is a re-use payment. And so when it is replayed, the first time it's replayed, the show, it's 75% of the original. And then the next couple of times I think it's 50% and then it keeps reducing, being reduced until you're down to about 5%. And then there's foreign re-use. If it's shown in a foreign market then that's another payment, not nearly as substantial, but there is some payment.

MR: So it's always probably a little adventure when you get your statement, and say what are they doing now.

BH: Oh yeah.

MR: Oh you probably say I played on that.

BH: Well sometimes you have to go after it though.

MR: Is that when you call the union? Is that your first call and say look—

BH: Yeah, and try to get them to help you, yeah.

MR: Can you recall any memorable moments in all those live T.V. shows that stick out for you?

BH: Oh there was, when we were doing the Carol Burnett Show, it was done at CBS, which is down at — well you don't know the city but it's down on Fairfax and Beverly which is down in West Los Angeles sort of, near Beverly Hills. And they had some soap operas that were done there also. And they had these sets that were set up permanently, like a drawing room, that they would re-use and they would leave them set up permanently. And they were fully, I guess you'd say decorated, with things on the tables and

everything. And there were a couple of guys that used to go shopping on the breaks that were in the band, and they'd steal things. And these same, this same two people, there was a restaurant we used to eat at on our breaks that we'd go to and they had these huge pepper mills. They were about three feet tall I guess, or four maybe. I mean the waiter would have to stand back from the table to make it to the salad or whatever he's putting it on. Well they stole one of those, put it under their jacket and just walked out with it. And then Carol Burnett would have wonderful Christmas parties. She'd have them at the Los Angeles Yacht Club. And she'd hire name bands. We had Basie's band one time, this was for the cast and crew of the show. And wonderful buffets, you couldn't ask for better. And there was this huge silver candelabra that somebody stole. And I never found out for sure but we always suspected it might have been our same kleptos.

MR: Oh gee, I've heard of some bad habits of musicians, but not that one.

BH: Well I mean, and these people were well to do. I mean as far as musicians go, they did well. And it wasn't the money, it was the adventure I guess. That's strange. You know I'm sure there are many — like for instance, I can't give you specific instances, but on the Carol Burnett Show, Jonathan Winters was a frequent guest there and he was just sensational. And he used to always love to come over to the band area and entertain the band, which he would do. And that was always fun. And that show was with Tim Conway, and Harvey Korman, that was as much fun as I ever had watching those guys work. Tim Conway would just completely destroy Harvey Korman. Harvey Korman could not continue, you know, he was just breaking up so much. It was a lot of fun. That made the work a lot of fun.

MR: I can't imagine how you guys would keep playing without laughing.

BH: Well I'll tell you the way — almost all live television shows were done the same. They were done in two days. You had a rehearsal and a pre-record the night before, which you would pre-record most of the important music. And then when the show was live, like they usually, during this one period of time there was almost always a chorus of maybe six singers, plus a dance group. And they had musical numbers that were quite extravagant. And so those were sort of tricky, and so the band didn't have to play over and over and over again, they would pre-record them. Sometimes they'd have to be re-done. And they would tape the show twice. What they called a dress rehearsal and then the so-called main show. Both of them had audiences. And then they would pick the best of the two. But most of the music was pre-recorded. Mostly we'd just play a little [scats] a play out or something, just a couple bar incidental music. Occasionally there'd be a live number and we'd do the whole thing, but most of it was prerecorded. So a lot of this time

when all this wonderful stuff was going on, the comedy, we weren't actually playing, so we could just sit there and enjoy it.

MR: You could be in the audience too.

BH: Yeah.

MR: It must have kept quite a number of arrangers pretty busy too.

BH: Yes it did. Yeah that was a very busy period, the 60s and 70s of live television. Unfortunately the shows, almost all of them had pretty much the same format. There'd be the principal, like Dean or Carol Burnett or whoever. And then they'd have guests, and the principal would do their shtick, and then they'd do bits with the guest, and then there would be the musical numbers and whatever. So whenever somebody would come to town, they would book them on four or five of these shows, somebody that didn't live here.

MR: I see.

BH: And they were in town maybe for a week, and they'd book them, and so they just overexposed a lot of things I think. And so now there aren't any musical variety shows now. I mean you can't call the talk shows musical variety shows, because they really aren't. Once in a while they'll have a musical number, but it's far from the kind of background music that they had in those early shows.

MR: Were there certain people that would come in as guests that were of questionable musical talent, that would try singing or whatever.

BH: Sure. I won't mention any names. And then surprisingly there were some people that you had no idea that they were able to do that. I didn't. There was a comic named Frank Fontaine.

MR: I remember him.

BH: He was on the Jackie Gleason show.

MR: Didn't he play the drunk?

BH: Yes he did indeed. And he had a delightful voice, which I didn't know.

MR: Well yeah it was almost like an Irish tenor.

BH: Exactly. That's correct. I was really impressed with that. And actually, as I recall Telly Savalas sounded pretty good when he sang on the Carol Burnett Show. He did, you know that deep voice and he sort of talked it a bit too, but I thought he did quite an acceptable job. But there were those who would really have a very poor sense of pitch and would either sing painfully flat or sharp, one or the other. But they were popular enough that they accepted it I guess.

MR: Who were some of your other bandmates that are pretty well known names now?

BH: In the television field?

MR: Yes.

BH: Well when I went on staff at NBC, Conrad Gozzo was still there and he was famous, one of the most famous lead trumpet players, number one in town for many years. And Joe Howard, the trombone player, was also the top rate trombone player. And the Carol Burnett show, when Peter Matz, who was from New York, became the band leader. I had known him when I was very young when he was going to UCLA I had done some work with him and when he was coming out here he called me and asked me if I'd like to come on that show. And he had some formidable players on that that he brought out with him from New York: Sol Gubin was the drummer, a marvelous drummer, Bob Tricarico was the saxophone/bassoon specialist, and Joe Soder was the contractor and he was a lead alto player, and he played well as well, a good flute player. And Chauncey Welsch, a trombone player, George Roberts, a famous bass trombone player, probably the father of the bass trombone. He was on a lot of these shows, and Dick Nole, another famous studio, a wonderful player, was on some of these as well. So there was a lot of people. Les Brown had — the staff rhythm section was former Les Brown people so when he got that show he was comfortable with them: Jack Sperling was the drummer and Rowley Bundock, who was with the original Glenn Miller band. Tony Rezey, the guitar player. So those were some of the names. There's not a whole lot of the people that during my big band experience on the road that actually did make it across the line into that. Now that did happen in the early days, because the motion picture orchestras were, except for the string players, were largely filled out by — a lot of them at least were filled out by the guys from the name bands that were famous, when the bands were famous. I mean Abe came from that and then he went on the staff, I think he was at Fox I believe. And he was there for many years. And many people like that came from the big bands. Well then the big band era was over and so they weren't coming from that anymore, and it was as I said just these ghost bands which didn't get the notoriety or the exposure, the airchecks weren't happening anymore, the radio broadcast remotes from the different ballrooms. The ballrooms weren't there even.

MR: What did you think about the advent of rock & roll when it came on?

BH: I didn't care much for it. It didn't seem very challenging to me.

MR: Did you get into positions where you needed to play some rock & roll tenor or—

BH: Yes. One of the things I did quite a bit of was, during one period of time, was records. And they were pop records, that was what it came from was the rock field. And I was never called upon too often to be a soloist, even though I had become fairly adept at being a jazz soloist. But I never really tried to play any other style than what I played. You know you have to accept me as I am. But I did do a lot of record dates of playing

that kind of music. And those were usually overdubs. You know the rhythm track is done and then they put the voices on or whatever, and then they'd add a horn section. And I did a lot of that playing the baritone mostly on those.

MR: What kind of people, do you recall?

BH: Oh everybody. I'm not going to — sometimes I didn't even know who it was.

MR: Oh right. You just put the headphones on and read your part.

BH: Yeah because I must say I did it for the money, but there was good people to play with so that helped too. First rate players you know. We maybe would have two trumpets and a trombone and maybe two saxophones. The five horns maybe. And we just did all kinds of things. One time we did a thing with a small band and it was a Japanese motion picture, and we had no idea at all what the picture was about. I mean they weren't showing it on the screen or anything, we were just recording this music. And this Japanese promoter got in the booth and we heard him say, "Pray back please, pray back." And so we thought it was a religious picture maybe. And it turned out to be a Godzilla movie.

MR: No kidding. Oh gosh. Well when you watch T.V. these days, every once in a while do you hear yourself?

BH: Occasionally, yeah occasionally, in some old pictures. And they did re-show, the Laugh-In series was on six years, and that was re-shown over a period of eight months, five nights a week. And that was very lucrative. Because those were the first re-showings, so as I told you the percentages were way up there, of your pay. And boy that was terrific. But I love the show anyway, and I would watch them as much as I could and I could hear those. And occasionally all of a sudden I'll say hey wait a minute, I think I did that.

MR: At the time Laugh-In was on, was there a sense of like I can't believe these guys are doing this now, on T.V.? Some of the political stuff they did?

BH: Oh yeah. Oh well I think — I would say I think it would be as good today to watch as it was then. Because the humor was humor, and what a great cast they had. Goldie Hawn was just adorable, she was very young then. I think she was 20 at that time or something. And she was just adorable. And Arte Johnson and JoAnne Worley, these people were just — it was a great show, a lot of fun.

MR: What a way to make a living.

BH: Well you know I never did anything — other kind of work after high school. I worked when I was in high school I did a little other work, but I never did anything else except music, I was able to make my living at it, I was fortunate. Because that doesn't happen to very many people. And it's probably harder now even than it was then. I know that some of my younger friends now really have to do a lot, I mean have to do everything. A little bit of theater and then maybe community theater, which is a lower scale, places like the

Schubert across the street which has a great scale. If you get one of those jobs that pays good money. And they have to do concerts with little orchestras or they do dance gigs and whatever they can.

MR: Do you know if the union has a minimum requirement for people in the pits these days?

BH: Yes they do. And they vary. There's different contracts. There's the Nederlander Corporation has some theaters and then there's other groups that have other theaters, and each one of those is a separate negotiation also. And they have to negotiate for the pit. And then another problem they have is when a traveling show comes in it used to be that they'd have to pay a certain number of local musicians, even though they didn't play. I mean that's because they were displacing jobs by bringing a traveling orchestra in. And I'm not sure, I think that's different now, that's changed. I've been out of that field for a long time. But when they bring the whole thing, or they bring a track, the whole thing recorded. Now we were picketing just a couple of months ago when the Rockettes show was here. And it appeared over at the Universal Ampitheater. And they had a completely recorded—

MR: Taped music.

BH: Taped music for these people dancing. And part of the excitement is the live music you know I would think. But we lost.

MR: No kidding.

BH: Yeah. We couldn't get anything done about it.

MR: Well I noticed from where we live that the shows will come in and the number of real live people in the pits for those traveling shows has sunk to almost nothing. The electronics have replaced people like crazy.

BH: Sure. Well they usually do it without strings at all, and just use the synthesizers for the string sounds, which are probably closer to sounding reasonable than the woodwinds. They don't seem to be able to get the woodwinds, there's something about the overtones or something that is hard for them to get, thankfully.

MR: It's too bad people in the audience don't stand up and say that's not real.

BH: Well they don't really know. So many motion pictures are being made right now, this is a very busy field, that's one of the busiest things in this town, they're making a lot of motion pictures. Lots of them. And almost all of them, every one I see, a lot of it is electric music. And then conversely, they'll have hundred-piece orchestras on some of them. So I don't know.

MR: Let me ask you about some of the records you've been on. Early 50s, with Ken Hanna?

BH: Yes I did an album with Ken Hanna had quite a few solos actually to play on that album, and that was a good band, a local band. It never went anywhere. I think Ken was a — I

learned this after I was on the band — that he had been an arranger for Stan Kenton, which I didn't know until afterwards. But that was a good band. That's a pretty good album. Every ten, fifteen years I may get it out and play it again.

MR: Yeah. Check it out. See if it's holding up.

BH: See if it's all right.

MR: And you played with Buddy DeFranco?

BH: Yes I did. Well I did an album with him, I didn't work with him in clubs or concerts or anything, but I was called to do an album with him and that was very good personnel, it was Jimmy Rowles was on that, that's one of my favorite piano players, and Barney Kessel was on it, another favorite, and Sweets Edison was on it, and Buddy DeFranco and myself. And I don't think I can remember who the bass player was right now, somebody formidable though. That was fun. I enjoyed doing that. I didn't get a lot of chance to do anything that down, really a jazz album as that was. I did a couple of albums with a drummer out here who was with Woody Herman at one time, his name is Chuck Flores. Excellent drummer, and he had a band. Bobby Shew was the trumpet player and Bob Magnusson, an excellent bass player. And we did a couple of albums with that band. And that was good. I enjoyed that. And we played with that band out quite a bit, and that was pretty well organized. And then Jimmy Rowles — now this hasn't to do with recording though, you were talking about recording — but one of my favorite jobs was with Jimmy Rowles when he had a quintet. And at this time he was very much into Wayne Shorter's music. And he had arranged all of these Wayne Shorter originals for trumpet and tenor and three rhythm. And we played at a club in town every Thursday for about eight months. And that was really something to look forward to. I was really busy at that time working in the studios. But it was really something to look forward to, to go in and play with that band. Conte Candoli was the trumpet player, and that was a lot of fun.

MR: Yeah, there's some challenging music there too, from a soloing standpoint.

BH: That's right. Some sophisticated changes that were demanding, yeah challenging is the word, that's right. So that was fun. And a few things like that through the years don't have a lot of record solo space. The first solo I played on a record was on a Billy May record called "Bacchanalia" and that was in 1953 I think. That was the first solo I played on a record. And then Ken Hanna was sort of in that period of time. And then Bethlehem hired me to do an album of my own in 1955 and that's when they were still making ten inch LPs so that's what it was. And that's the only album I ever did on my own. And through that though, you might enjoy this story, we used to have a little joke thing we'd do when we'd be playing or something, get together playing with friends, just for fun, or

just hanging out or whatever. And the phone would ring and you'd say, "Oh maybe it's Benny Goodman." Well one time it was. And he complimented me on that album. He had heard it in New York. And he subsequently hired me to sub on the movie "The Benny Goodman Story" when they were making that movie, to replace Stan Getz. I didn't have to solo, but to replace Stan Getz who had some court thing he had to appear at, or I don't know what the details were. So I met him. And then around the same time I got a call from Woody Herman and that was something I always wanted to do. I had played in a lot of bands by then and that was the one band I really wanted to play on, because that was a tenor player's band.

MR: Yeah, absolutely.

BH: A Four Brothers type band. And so I agreed to join that band. And while I was in New York rehearsing, we were there a week early before we were going to start, I started on that band on New Years of 1955. And while I was in New York a call was sent from L.A. back there to me from Benny Goodman. And I subsequently went to a rehearsal of his, during the same time I was rehearsing with Woody.

MR: Both in New York?

BH: Both in New York. It was a pretty exciting period of time for a young fellow. But as much as I loved Benny Goodman himself, his playing, Woody Herman's music was more what I had in mind. So I stayed with Woody. So that was sort of fun.

MR: How long did you stay with Woody Herman?

BH: One year. And three months of that time he broke down to an eight piece band he had, with one tenor only, and I was picked to be the tenor for that. So that was fun. We played locations with that, like in Las Vegas and Reno. And that was fun. And Bill Harris, the famous trombone player on the early Woody Herman band had just come back at that time when I joined the band, this was the new big band. And then he was on that band, and he was an exciting player. And also on that band was another famous guy, Victor Feldman had just come over and this was the first time that Woody Herman had a vibraphone player since Terry Gibbs. Many years had gone by since he'd had a vibraphone player. But he did. He had Victor. So that made the band sort of a little special. And then in the little band Victor played drums.

MR: Why was Benny Goodman calling to get you to sub for Stan Getz — they were doing "The Benny Goodman Story?"

BH: Well yes. He had talked to me on the phone, complimenting me on the album. And let's see, if I remember it right, I think he knew at that time that Stan had to take off this one day, because this was set way in advance, this court date, and that may have been the way —

MR: Okay. I didn't know that Benny Goodman was that involved in the actual motion picture, that he was like a music contractor almost or that he was right in the middle of that.

BH: Well I guess he was able to. Actually we didn't record anything that day I was there, we didn't do a whole lot, which is the way motion pictures are. A lot of times you just sit around all day. We didn't do a lot I know. But it was just an honor to be there.

MR: I wonder if he liked the result.

BH: Oh gee, I don't know. Steve Allen you know. He did fine I guess.

MR: Yeah. It's a somewhat fictionalized account.

BH: Oh yeah. It Hollywoodized the whole thing. Same way with "The Glenn Miller Story."

MR: Right.

BH: Remember that "Orchestra Wives?" Remember that movie and the gal who wanted to carry her vacuum cleaner on the road?

MR: I can tell there was no musicians involved in writing the script.

BH: John Payne.

MR: Well what are you up to these days?

BH: Well I'm pretty much retired now. I've actually gone exactly the opposite direction than I was for those 20 years I was working in the studios. I don't really care about playing the woodwinds anymore at all. I don't bother with them unless I know in advance something's coming up that I want to do and then I'll have to spend a week or so woodshedding, so I'll be okay. I've been going to Japan for the last 20 years off and on, with a number of different bands, which I enjoy. I enjoy the trips in Japan. And so I do that usually once a year. This year, '99 at this point I don't know that I'm going. But I'm still playing as much as I can. I still practice and I play with friends as much as I can, and I actually turn down most casual type engagements, like dances or that kind of thing, because I don't really enjoy them and I don't have to, I don't need to do it. So that's about it. I'm just trying to keep myself together and keep myself healthy so I can last a few more years.

MR: Well that's great. All the time you put into the studio is helping pay off now I would imagine.

BH: Yes, yes. Well we have, the young people don't really know how valuable it is and that's why they do a lot of work unreported off the record, for under scale and things. But the musician's pension fund is a very strong and stable fund, and I happened to be working, and all the work I was doing was legitimate, and so contributions were made to that so that pension is helping me a lot. And I'm also old enough that I'm getting my Social Security and so financially I'm okay because I do own my own home, and so I don't have

a whole lot of expenses, so that allows me to be pretty choosy in taking in any jobs, which is pretty neat.

MR: Yeah. That's nice, to be able to pick and choose a little bit. You don't have to go and do that wedding reception.

BH: Yeah. I still really do like to play the saxophone and I play every week at least once with friends, we just get together and blow, and I do still enjoy that.

MR: Were you in the studios when the union became integrated?

BH: You mean the black and the white?

MR: Yes, the two unions.

BH: No that was before my time.

MR: That was late 40s I guess.

BH: Yeah. Because I didn't get into the studios until the 60s. See I was scuffling until I told you I tried to figure out why, and then I took those other doubles, and that turned things around for me. But no I was not, as a matter of fact when I joined the union — you've probably never seen our union building, but it's been there for many, many years — but when I joined it our union was in a different place, it was in downtown Los Angeles. And there were two locals at that time, the black and white local. And I went down and joined down there in L.A. That's way back. Not many people remember that. As a matter of fact I've been a member for 55 years with the union.

MR: You should be a lifetime member is that right?

BH: I am. And it's sort of a humorous thing, they printed it in our local paper, it said, "When people have been a member 50 years we invite them to come down and get their 50 year gold pin" at a meeting, a general meeting, and then stand up and people give you a hand. I've never been invited.

MR: No kidding.

BH: I don't care because I don't really want the pin. What would I do with it? I wouldn't wear it you know. But it's sort of humorous.

MR: Do they give you a waiver on your dues when you get 50 years?

BH: When you become a lifetime member you have a reduction in your yearly dues. You still have to pay as much — see we're the only union in the world that I know of, except no I guess the actors do — that pay work dues. A percentage of our income goes to the union. As a matter of fact I was audited on my income tax one time because they couldn't believe that that was the case. Some uninformed guy from there, and I just proved it to him so it was no problem, but you still pay that as long as you work you still pay that.

MR: All right. Well I've been fascinated to talk to you and get the inside scoop on some of this stuff I haven't heard before.

BH: Well I hope something was of some interest perhaps.

MR: Absolutely.

BH: Yeah.

MR: That's the first time I heard kind of the inside story about live T.V. and all that, it's really great.

BH: Yeah, right now because of the motion pictures and because of theater, theater is very good in Los Angeles now, and that's about the only thing that is very good now in Los Angeles, so the motion picture industry, the musicians that are being employed are really supporting our local union here, and that's good, because the guys that are on the inside of that field are keeping very busy now, they're doing well. So that's all good stuff. And then as I say the theaters, the major theaters like the Schubert and so forth, they have very good scales too. Some guys can make a really nice living by doing one of these shows that runs a year or two you know. So that's the best part of the business right now I think.

MR: All right. Well thanks for your time today.

BH: Monk, nice to meet you. A pleasure. Thank you.